UTTAR PRADESH

THE HALAL HULLABALOO

By Prashant Srivastava



KOSHER OR NOT? Officials checking products at a mall in Gorakhpur, Nov. 21

ANI

The use of a 'halal' tag that certifies if a product is 'permissible' for consumption under Islamic laws is, ironically, not permitted in Uttar Pradesh anymore. While the Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath-led state government says the ban is meant to crack down on the nexus that is exploiting religious sentiments to boost sales, the Opposition has accused the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) regime of pushing yet another divisive agenda for political gains.

It was on November 18 that the UP government ordered a ban on production, storage, distribution and sale of halal-certified products across the state, a day after the Lucknow police booked four organisations—the Jamiat Ulama-i-Hind Halal Trust, Delhi; Halal India Private Limited, Chennai; the Halal Council of India, Mumbai and the Jamiat Ulema Maharashtra—for allegedly issuing forged halal certificates to various companies for financial gains and fomenting social discord.

According to a source in the CM's office, Yogi Adityanath had been receiving multiple complaints from local vendors about private firms minting money by issuing halal certificates. In one such instance reported from Varanasi, the official alleged that halal certification had been imposed on the sale of sarees too. Per a government statement, the ban was necessitated due to the "unrestrained propaganda...within a particular section of society... [that] harms the business interests of other communities". Notably, the ban exempts products intended for export.

Anita Singh, additional chief secretary, Food Safety and Drug Administration, told INDIA TODAY that as many as 92 UP-based manufacturers have been getting halal certification for their products from organisations that are based outside the state. (All such organisations are required to be accredited to the National Accreditation Board for Certification Bodies.) In the first 10 days of the ban, Singh revealed, the department carried out 92 raids and investigated 482 establishments across 38 districts, collecting 81 samples for testing and seizing 3,000 kg products.

While welcoming the move, Maulana Shahabuddin, a cleric from Bareilly's Aala Hazrat Dargah, said that a halal certificate is normally given to non-vegetarian items, but now it is being used for vegetables, confectionery and other products as well, which is "absolutely wrong". But Niaz Ahmed Farooqui, chief executive officer (CEO) of the Jamiat Ulama-i-Hind Halal Trust, said that a halal tag on items like rice, sugar and cosmetics is meant to certify that no animal-derived or prohibited ingredient is used in chemical processes that go into their manufacturing. "We provide halal certificates only for export purposes, and follow the government procedure," he claimed, even as he wondered why the organisation had been named in the FIR.

The Opposition Samajwadi Party (SP), meanwhile, has questioned the Yogi regime's "double standard". "Why have they exempted the products meant for export?" asked SP spokesperson Fakhrul Hasan Chand. "If they claim unrestrained propaganda is going on in the name of halal products, why didn't they impose a blanket ban?" Congress state president Ajay Rai echoed the sentiment as he accused the BJP government of resorting to divisive politics. But BJP spokesperson Rakesh Tripathi defended the move and sought strict action against all defaulters. Now to see whether other BJP-ruled states will follow suit. ■

THE ROW

- **The Yogi regime has banned the use of halal tag, except on products meant for export**
- **It's meant to bust the certification nexus, say officials, that's exploiting religious sentiments for financial gains**
- **But opposition parties have accused the BJP of resorting to a divisive agenda ahead of elections**